Used to (past habits)

Goal: To talk about past habits and past states that are no longer true using "used to", in affirmative, negative and question forms, and to contrast past and present.

The idea in two lines: "Used to + base verb" describes something that happened regularly or was true in the past but is not true now: People used to travel by camel. Negatives and questions use "didn't use to" and "Did ... use to...?"

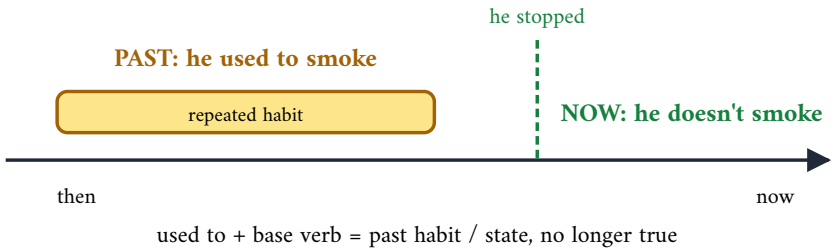


Figure 1: "Used to" places a habit in the past and implies that it has stopped.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Affirmative:** subject + **used to** + base verb, same form for all subjects: I used to play, she used to play.
2. **Negative:** subject + **didn't use to** + base verb (no -d on "use"): We didn't use to have a car.
3. **Question: Did** + subject + **use to** + base verb? Did you use to live in Algiers? Short answers: Yes, I did. / No, I didn't.
4. **Meaning:** a repeated past action (habit) or a past state (She used to be shy) that is no longer true.
5. **Contrast past / present:** People used to write letters; now they send messages. "But now / nowadays / today" introduces the present situation.
6. **Not for single events:** use the past simple instead: I visited Tlemcen last year (not "I used to visit Tlemcen last year").

7. **Do not confuse** with "be used to + verb-ing" (= be accustomed to): I am used to getting up early.

🟢 Examples

1. Rewrite: In the past, my grandfather walked to school every day. **Answer:** My grandfather used to walk to school every day. **Explanation:** a repeated past habit that has stopped → used to + walk.
2. Make the question: Your mother / wear / traditional dresses? **Answer:** Did your mother use to wear traditional dresses? **Explanation:** did + subject + use to (without -d) + base verb.
3. Correct the mistake: She didn't used to like fish. **Answer:** She didn't use to like fish. **Explanation:** after "didn't" the verb takes its base form.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing "use to" in the affirmative: "He use to play" instead of "He used to play".
- Keeping "used" after did / didn't: "Did he used to...?"
- Using "used to" for a single past event with a date or "last year".
- Confusing "used to + verb" (past habit) with "be used to + verb-ing" (accustomed).

🟡 Quick review

- used to + base verb = past habit or state, not true now.
- Negative: didn't use to; question: Did ... use to ...?
- Same form for every subject.
- Not for one event at a specific time → past simple instead.
- Contrast with "but now / nowadays".

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